TRAPS (5E, 2024 RULES) – DESCRIPTION

Traps should stay **rare**: too many make players overly cautious and slow the game. The best are brief distractions that skilled characters overcome quickly, or deadly puzzles that call for thought and cooperation. An undetectable, unavoidable trap is rarely fun.

The parts of a trap:

- **Severity and levels**: a trap is a nuisance or deadly for certain character levels.
- **Trigger**: a pressure plate, a tripwire, a door handle, the wrong key in a lock.
- **Duration**: instantaneous, or in rounds, minutes, hours. With no reset mentioned, the trap is inert after activation.
- Depending on the trap: Avoid, Detect and Disarm, Escape, Higher Levels.

Building a trap – Nuisance:

Levels	Attack bonus	Save DC	Damage
1–4	+4	10–12	5 (1d10)
5–10	+4	12–14	11 (2d10)
11–16	+4	14–16	22 (4d10)
17–20	+4	16–18	55 (10d10)

Building a trap – Deadly:

Levels	Attack bonus	Save DC	Damage
1–4	+8	13–15	11 (2d10)
5–10	+8	15–17	22 (4d10)
11–16	+8	17–19	55 (10d10)
17–20	+8	19–21	99 (18d10)

If the trap also applies a condition, reduce the damage. Be careful with a lower-level group: a nuisance can become deadly.

⚠ Example traps:

Collapsing Roof · Falling Net · Fire-Breathing Statue · Hidden Pit · Poison Darts · Poison Needle · Rolling Stone · Spiked Pit.

Step 1 – Prepare the trap:

Choose the severity, the party's level, the trigger, the effect, and the duration. Always provide a way to detect or avoid it.

Step 2 – Detect the trap:

With the **Search** action, a character examines the trapped element: a Wisdom (Perception) check. With the **Study** action, an Intelligence (Investigation) check. The DC is given by the trap (e.g. DC 15).

Step 3 – Trigger the trap:

When the trigger occurs, the trap acts: an attack roll or saving throw by the target, damage per the table, a condition if any.

Step 4 – Disarm the trap:

Once detected, an action can disarm it: a Dexterity (Sleight of Hand) check, DC 15, with Thieves' Tools. A failure triggers the trap.

Example: a poison needle (nuisance, level 1–4) hides its lock. Mira (Perception +4) uses Search: 12 + 4 = 16, against DC 15, she spots it. Brann (Sleight of Hand +6) disarms: 9 + 6 = 15, success. Otherwise: a DC 11 Constitution save, 5 (1d10) Poison damage and the Poisoned condition for 1 hour (half damage on a success).

Step 5 – Avoid or escape:

- **Avoid**: some traps don't trigger depending on the method (a lock opened with the right key).
- **Escape**: to climb out of a smooth-walled pit, you need a Climb Speed, gear, or a spell (see the **Rope** sheet).

Step 6 – Adapt to higher levels:

Increase the damage and DC per the table of the chosen severity.

⚠ Change from 2014

Severity goes from three tiers (setback, dangerous, deadly) to two: **nuisance** and **deadly**. The tables give a fixed attack bonus (+4, +8) and total damage. The example traps state the detection action (Search or Study) and its DCs.

⚠ Flaw in the rule and fixes

Table rule

There is no universal DC to detect a trap, nor a general rule for a failed disarm. Fix: the **DM sets the DC before the game** and leaves a described clue.

💡 Narrative option: Table rule

Describe the clues: no dust on a flagstone, a barely visible wire, a lock with fresh scratches.

Questions:

Can I search every square of the room?

Yes, but Search is an action and targets a specific element (a lock, a flagstone). The DM describes what is examined. Tip: if the clue is obvious, skip the roll. Table rule

Do I need Thieves' Tools to disarm?

Thieves' Tools allow disarming (DC 15, Dexterity). A Rogue Thief does it with a Bonus Action (Fast Hands).

Do I get a bonus with Sleight of Hand and the tools?

Yes: being proficient in both the tool and the skill gives Advantage.

Does a failure always trigger the trap?

For the needle, yes. Otherwise the DM decides by the trap. Table rule

Can an ally help?

Yes, with the **Help** action: Advantage on the next check with the chosen skill.

Does a trap reset?

Only if its Duration says so. Otherwise it is inert after activation.

Can a trap kill a level 1 character?

A level 1–4 deadly trap deals 11 (2d10) damage. A trap built for a higher level is far deadlier.

Can I dispel a magical trap?

The text doesn't say: the DM decides. Table rule

⚠ Rule clarifications (answers found on the web, reworded):

Resistance and damage

Resistance can reduce damage to 0 but never below. It applies after other adjustments: on a successful save that still deals damage, Resistance halves it again.

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